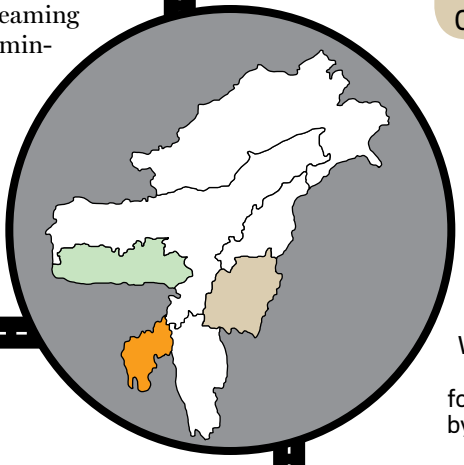
NORTHEAST POLLS

THE ROAD AHEAD

THOUGH THE ELECTORATE OPTED FOR CONTINUITY OVER CHANGE, CMs SANGMA, RIO AND SAHA WILL HAVE TO WALK A TIGHTROPE

By Kaushik Deka

On March 2, when the results of assembly elections in three northeastern states—Meghalaya, Nagaland and Tripura—were declared, one common thread was the BJP's emergence as the governing party in all three—on its own in Tripura and as the junior alliance partner in the other two. The saffron party almost repeated its performance in these states, reaping the benefits of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's consistent focus on developing and mainstreaming the remote region. The three winning chief ministers, though relieved to have beaten anti-incumbency, now have multiple challenges to address, primarily protecting their political capital and ensuring fast-track development of their states, which have remained behind the national average on several socio-economic indices.



CONRAD K. SANGMA, 45
Chief Minister, Meghalaya

CHALLENGES

- Manage a stable coalition. The contrasting demands from allies may force CM Sangma to compromise on his governance agenda
- Secure NPP's political future in face of ally BJP's big ambitions
- Urban unemployment is a major concern
- Maintain law and order and resolve border disputes with Assam without hurting local sentiments
- Tackle the demand for a Khasi CM



NEIPHIU RIO, 72
Chief Minister, Nagaland

CHALLENGES

- Work together with the Centre to find a solution to the Naga insurgency
- Improve the abysmal state of infrastructure
- Maintain the stability of the NDPP-BJP alliance. With 23 MLAs spread across smaller parties, the BJP can form a government on its own by triggering mass defections



MANIK SAHA, 70
Chief Minister, Tripura

CHALLENGES

- Tackle the state's high unemployment rate
- Ward off the claims of other CM aspirants such as Pratima Bhoumik; any mistake may result in the claimants hankering for a replacement, just as in the BJP's first tenure
- Delicately handle the tensions between indigenous tribals and Bengali population; negotiate with Tipra Motha, which has been demanding a separate state

